

How does public trust in government institutions influence compliance with economic policies such as taxation or austerity measures?

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Abstract

Taxation is considered to be one of the most important elements of governance. It is prevalent in the majority of the world and functions under different rules in different countries. The basic idea however follows that the government demands a sum of money from the citizens on their incomes, purchases and business and then uses this money to fuel infrastructure, health, defense and educational needs, the only catch being that it is often not this simple and fair. Where on one hand, people and companies try to save the money that is to be paid to authorities, the authorities may also use it to serve their own pockets. Ultimately, it is a system that runs on honesty and cooperation and if that gets hampered, can cause loss to the whole country. This paper will discuss the nature, definition and various types of taxes, shaping the argument comprehensively through real life examples and will try to study the relationship between the government's competence and public trust.

Keywords: Taxation, Tax Evasion, Austerity, Public Policies, Welfare, Corruption.

1. Introduction

1.1 Taxation: Definition, Basic concept and Types.

In simple words, taxation or tax is a mandatory payment demanded by the government from businesses and individuals to keep the country functioning. It comes from the latin word *taxere* or *taxo* which means ‘to assess something’s worth’ (Levare, n.d). It can be derived from multiple sources like income, realty and commerce and is used to fuel essential public infrastructure like transportation, education, healthcare, defense etc and measures like allowances, scholarships that uphold social welfare and equality. Taxation is a very broad subject and encompasses multiple types and categories. Every kind of tax is designed differently and runs on a separate set of rules (Kotak Life, 2025) and given the fact that it is a very significant aspect that governs our daily lives, it is important for everyone to know about it. This paper will base its research in the Indian context, although will discuss global aspects whenever required.

The amount of tax to be paid depends on multiple factors like income level, property ownership etc. There are two broad categories of taxes namely direct and indirect tax. Direct tax is paid straight to the government, involving no intermediaries and the burden of it can’t be transferred. An example of it is the income tax, which is to be paid to the government on the profits earned by individuals or firms. Income tax deduction is based on categories called ‘slabs’ which apply different sets of rules to different earning groups. Firstly, tax slabs do not apply to individuals above the age of 60. Currently in India, two options are available for taxpayers; the old tax regime and the new tax regime. The old regime allows taxpayers to reduce their taxable income by applying for deduction under section 80C (for investments like PPF, EPF and life insurance premiums) and section 80D (health insurance premiums). It also offers them exemptions from house rent allowance (HRA) and leave travel allowance (LTA) etc. The new

tax regime offers a simplified structure with lower rates but it is strict on the provision of many reductions and deductions. However, under section 87A rebate may be applicable, making low income levels tax-free effectively under both regimes, 5 and 7 lakhs respectively (KotakLife, 2025).

Given below are tax slabs under the old and new regimes:

Old Tax Regime

Taxable Income Slab (₹)	Tax Rate
Up to 2,50,000	Nil
2,50,001 - 5,00,000	5%
5,00,001 - 10,00,000	₹12,500 + 20%
Above 10,00,000	₹1,12,500 + 30%

New Tax Regime

Taxable Income Slab (₹)	Tax Rate
Up to 3,00,000	Nil
3,00,001 - 7,00,000	5%
7,00,001 - 10,00,000	₹20,000 + 10%
10,00,001 - 12,00,000	₹50,000 + 15%
12,00,001 - 15,00,000	₹80,000 + 20%
Above 15,00,000	₹1,40,000 + 30%

(KotakLife, 2025)

Direct taxation in India is governed by the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT). On the other hand, indirect taxes are levied on goods and services, with the burden passed on to the ultimate consumer along the supply chain. Indirect taxes in the country are administered by the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) (Surana, 2025). Given below is a table that enlists different kinds of taxes under broad brackets:

Taxes		
Direct Taxes	Indirect Taxes	Other Taxes
Income Tax	Sales Tax	Property Tax
Corporate Tax	Service Tax	Registration Fees
Securities Transaction Tax	Octroi Duty	Toll Tax
Capital Gains Tax	Custom Duty	Education Cess
Gift Tax	Value Added Tax (VAT)	Entertainment Tax
Wealth Tax	Goods & Services Tax (GST)	Professional Tax

(Surana, 2025)

Certain important taxes that come under direct taxes are prerequisite tax, capital gain tax, corporate tax and property tax. Prerequisites are the non-monetary benefits provided by an employer to employees. These include off site accommodations, travel allowance or other reimbursements. The taxation on these depends on specific provisions under income tax legislation. Capital gain taxes are applied on the profit from the sales of capital assets like mutual funds, company shares or properties. They are further categorized as long term capital gains

(LTCG) and short term capital gains (STCG). The treatment of these depends on the nature of assets and the length of time it was held for. Corporate tax is demanded from corporations and businesses on the basis of their net incomes post deducting allowable expenses and the tax amount depends on companies size and specific jurisdiction. Likewise, property tax is levied annually on the real estate owned by individuals and businesses. (Kotak Life, 2025)

Similarly, the major types of indirect taxes are sales tax, value-added tax (VAT), excise duty, custom duty, entertainment tax, and goods and services tax (GST). Sales tax is applied on the sale of goods and services at the very point of purchase. It is collected by the retailers on behalf of the government and is calculated as a percentage of the purchase price, VAT on the other hand is a consumption tax levied on every stage of production and distribution cycle. It is calculated based on the difference between sales and cost price. Excise duty is another indirect tax imposed on sales and production of specified products like tobacco, fuel, alcohol and luxury items. Custom duties are applied on international trade and entertainment tax is levied on leisure activities like concerts, movies, festivals etc (KotakLife, 2025). However, with the introduction of GST in India in 2017, the tax-on-tax domino effect in India has ended as it has majorly subsumed many indirect taxes like VAT and sales tax, however, these are not entirely obsolete. For instance, GST excludes petrol, diesel, aviation and turbine fuel, natural gas, crude oil and alcohol, items which are still governed by VAT (PWC, 2025).

1.2: A Brief History of Taxation in India

Apart from adding to the conceptual clarity on taxation, this section will also look at the dynamics of public trust and austerity measures from a historical perspective in India, giving a head start for the discussions that are to follow.

In the ancient vedic ages, much before the formal tax systems evolved, the mention of tax is found in the *Manusmriti* (2nd century BC to 2nd century BCE) which details a system in which the king can ethically draw money from his subjects and in return, provide good governance, safety and promote social welfare. It further mentioned the penalties for those officials who unlawfully threaten the poor or seize their properties (Bhat, 2024). By the third century BCE, we see the system get more formalized and during the Mauryan empire, the wealthy class was made to pay approximately 1/6th of their earnings to the state which was used to fuel public infrastructure. With time, taxation kept growing and expanded largely under the Mughal rule where various taxes like *Kharaj* (on agricultural produce) and *Jiziya* (on non-muslims) were imposed (Levare, n.d.). The British rule in India brought some stability to the structure but relied on extractive and oppressive measures. Their major source of tax revenue was the land-oriented taxes like *Zamindari* system (fixed land tax, burden on landlords and farmers), *Ryotwari* system (extracted from peasants) and *Mahalwari* system (extracted from village communities) (PK IAS Academy, 2024).

The income tax as we know it today was introduced in 1860 by the British under James Wilsom and was arguably brought in to compensate for the losses incurred by the Raj during the rebellion of 1857. Thereafter, the income tax act was passed in 1886 and had been under continuous scrutiny by the British ever since; in 1918 to counter the disastrous World War 1 and again in 1922. Post independence, the Income Tax Act, currently functional, has been in operation since 1st April, 1962 (Levare, n.d.).

1.3 Tax Evasion and penalties

Tax evasion refers to the deliberate act of not paying taxes owed to the government. Just like any other offense, it is deemed fraudulent and can attract monetary fines and imprisonment (Tata

AIG, n.d.). Although there are multiple reasons why it is done and various factors that affect it which will be discussed in the chapters to follow, the two primary reasons for tax evasion are dissatisfaction from government's use of tax money and second, the greed which makes people find and exploit the loopholes in taxation.

Regardless of what prompts tax evasion, it is considered a serious legal offense and intentional non-payment of tax liabilities are punishable under the Income Tax Act of 1961, under various different rules. If the income is under-stated, a penalty equivalent to 50% of tax payable can be levied. If it is misreported, the penalty may increase to 200% of tax payable on misreported income. Moreover, failure to file ITR (income tax return) by the due date invites a fine. From the financial year 2021/22, this fine can be up to 5000 Rs (or 1000 Rs if total income is less than 5 lakh Rs).if at least 90% of the calculated tax is not paid as advance tax by the end of financial year, interest at 1% per month is to be charged under section 234B (KotakLife, 2025).

2. Taxation, austerity measures and Public trust

After understanding the basics of taxation, it is vital to know what 'austerity' is. Austerity can be defined as a set of economic policies which are adopted by the government to battle budget deficits. These may include an increase in taxes or cutting on expenditures. Austerity measures are never the first choice of a government because they obviously go against public opinion. In cases of temporary crises or relatively smaller deficits, governments resort to borrowings. Moreover, implementation of austerity measures can be passed around as 'internal decisions' of a country in the international financial markets and do not lead to reduced credibility (Bondarenko, 2026). Historically, many nations have had to implement austerity

measures to bring them out of crisis, however, decisions like these are always controversial. Given below are some famous instances from history.

During the economic crisis of Argentina (1998 to 2002), the government resorted to strict austerity policies to try and restore financial stability and rebuild investors' confidence. These measures were consulted with and recommended by the International Monetary Fund (IMF), Argentina's principal international creditor. Under the structural adjustments that followed, government employees salaries were reduced, pensions were cut and fundings for numerous social welfare programs were decreased. Most importantly, taxes were increased to boost state revenues and counter the fiscal deficit. In return for implementing these harsh laws, Argentina got a substantial low-interest loan package from the IMF which helped stabilize the collapsing economy. Likewise, in 1998, when Russia faced a major financial crisis which caused currency devaluation and debt default, it adopted these rough fiscal consolidation measures too. Similarly in 2001, Turkey went through its own economic crisis and did respond with cuts in expenditure, structural reforms and tax adjustments designed to restore the balance. This phenomenon has been observed globally. During the economic crisis of 2007–09, several European countries were forced to introduce strict austerity policies. Countries like Greece, Spain, Portugal, Ireland, Italy, and the United Kingdom saw unprecedented reductions in public spending combined with significant tax increases. Taken together, these instances depict how austerity is often used as a crisis-management strategy and may have socio-economical consequences (Bondarenko, 2026)

2.1: Why people are reluctant to pay taxes

Tax evasion is a very common practice and is increasing rapidly over time. According to the official data of Government of India, during the financial year 2017-18, the income tax department registered over 2,225 cases of tax evasion, which is a 184% surge from 784 cases in

the preceding financial year. The government also adopted a rigorous approach, convicting 48 people in various tax evasion cases up to the end of November 2017 in contrast to 13 convictions in the immediately preceding year, marking a near quadruple increase. The punishments included imprisonment, monetary penalties and sometimes both (PIB, 2018). In India, only 2% of the population pays income tax and nearly 50% of all the companies that file ITR (income tax return) pay nothing. Although there have been debates about widening the income tax net, it is because of tax evasion, low salaries, high unemployment and high exemption that only a few people qualify to pay income taxes. Moreover, accounting loopholes, low audit quality and income tax reliefs provided in 2019 have caused very few corporations to actually pay income taxes. The top 9% tax filers pay 87% of the total tax and the top 1% of ITR filers pay 50% of the total personal income tax collection of India. This suggests a significantly high inequality and induces a heavy burden on these top 10% of filers, prompting them to evade tax. The situation is worse in corporates where out of more than 10 lakh corporate ITR filers, 57% report zero income and another 33% earn between Rs. 0-50 lakhs. In totality, 90% of companies show earnings of just up to Rs. 50 lakh. Not that the corporations are taxed on profits, not on income. Nearly half of the corporate filers pay zero income tax, while another 36% pay between Rs. 0-5 lakh in income tax. For instance, 84% of the corporate tax payers contributed almost nothing to the total corporate tax of Rs. 7.16 lakh crore collected in financial year 2023-24. Again, the top 1% of corporate ITR filers pay 85% of total corporate income tax (Tiwari, 2025).

There can be multiple reasons why tax evasion is rampant, not just in India but globally as well. According to the Inter-American Centre of Tax Administrations (CIAT), a primary reason for tax evasion sometimes is the complicated structure of taxation in a country that allows the people to exploit loopholes. Other than that, the high rate of taxes creates a 'tax pressure'.

People are more likely to evade tax when it feels unfair, disproportionate and hence, burdensome. It is also important to know that in the growing age of technological advancements, new formats of digital currencies are emerging and the field of e-commerce is continuously expanding. Owing to this, it has become easier to commit fraud and all the more difficult to track it down. It can also sometimes be carelessness on the government's front to educate and spread awareness about financial literacy in common people to do away with hysteria and rumours around tax (Collosa, 2019).

The dynamics of public trust and austerity measures or even just taxation are two-fold and obvious; people's trust in the government is directly proportional to their compliance with austerity measures and lack of trust leads to backlash and rebellion. When people know that the government cares for them and actually see their hard earned tax money being spent in infrastructural development, they believe the government's intentions when it increases the taxes too. In countries or regions with low corruption and higher rates of development, austerity measures may invite protests but the general public complies regardless as they believe that the cause might be legitimate. On the flipside, when the people observe that their tax money is being used to fill the pockets of greedy politicians whose children go to foreign universities and study while the people in the constituency struggle for basic amenities, when the roads are not built over years and the police is corrupt, or when the availability of justice has a cost only the rich can bear, it is obvious for the general public to erupt in anger when taxes go up. The lack of trust in government then turns an economic crisis into a legitimacy issue and a possible upheaval. To summarize the paragraph, it can be said that trust of the general public is key to the effectiveness of any government. Without it, it can neither function effectively nor implement welfare reforms

and so, trust is not just a by-product of good governance, it is responsible for its functioning (OECD, 2017).

The major connecting force between trust and austerity is the perceived fairness, competence and values of social welfare. If the general public views austerity policies to be equitable and implemented in a set-up where both elites and ordinary citizens share the burden, trust can exist but if measures appear biased or are not explained properly, it may erode quickly too. Austerity can also reshape trust over time. If the seemingly harsh policies ultimately prove to be successful in facilitating the economy with improved conditions, it attracts public trust but on the flip side, their failure might lead to prolonged hardship and trust may decline further.

3. Case Studies

This chapter will look at some of the most striking examples that unwind the complicated relationship between taxation, public trust and government policies from around the world. The discussion will include the responsibilities of government along with the duties of people.

One such case is of the EXPO Milano in 2015 which depicted how an integrated and genuine government effort can restore public support after the government's reputation has been compromised. In 2015, Italy was set to organize an international registered exhibition in Milan which required inputs from 145+ countries and 50 international organizations resulting in a combined effort of nearly 13 billion euros (Ariana, 2017). The EXPO was centred about tackling the questions of food production, healthy eating, population growth and optimal use of natural resources with its theme being 'Feeding the Planet, Energy for Life' (BIE, n.d.). In 2014, while the preparations for the big stage were being made, allegations of corruption and fraud in the procurement contracts emerged. Rather than suppressing the issue to avoid international shame,

the Italian authorities took a firm stance and granted the president of the National Anti Corruption Authority (ANAC) to supervise over the problems. Several arrests were made on grounds of misuse of power and public funds. Furthermore, an MoU was signed between ANAC and OECD (Organization of Economic Co-operation and Development), a union of 38 developed countries including Italy. This attested to seriousness and international accountability. Ultimately, the EXPO was a success and Italy did not lose its reputation in the eyes of its own people and the world. This could be achieved because of the integrity of the country's ruling class (OECD, 2017, pp. 33-34).

A lot of the trust issues between citizens and power holders arise because of the lack of transparency. Brazil's law on access to information is a good example in this regard where an attempt was initiated on the government's front to introduce institutional transparency. Implemented in 2012, the Access to Information (ATI) law of Brazil made governance transparent by empowering its citizens to the right to demand accountability and ask questions to any government agency through an e-SIC online platform and as expected, by 2015, over 334,000 requests were made and 99% of them were answered in an average of 11 days. Such positive steps by the authorities can surely foster trust and reliability among citizens (OECD, 2017, pp.111-112). Although there can surely be issues with implementation, an initiative like this can surely be considered successful if it is able to bring citizens and authorities to a common discussion ground.

Another interesting case study similar to the one discussed above is the Indian substitute to ATI is RTI (Right to Information) act which was implemented in 2005 but has had a different fate than ATI. Virtually, the potential of RTI allows it to make India a truly democratic nation with intellectually empowered citizens and functioning redressal machinery but that did not

happen. According to estimates from 2020, less than 3% of Indians have ever filed an RTI plea, which still makes up to 40-50 lakh people. Out of the reports filed, less than 45% received desired reply back but out of the ones that did not get their questions answered, just around 10% cared to file re-appeals. The officers in the concerned authorities like CIC (Chief Information Commission) and SIC (State Information Commission) are almost never held accountable for their late or false replies and as of March 2019, it was found that over 2 lakh appeals were pending before authorities, the number that must have surely increased by now. During demonetisation, multiple RTI applications were severely rejected by the Reserve Bank of India citing the section 8 of the RTI act which talk about exemptions, saying that certain information may affect ‘the sovereignty and integrity of India, the security, strategic, scientific or economic interests of the state, relation with foreign state or lead to incitement of an offence’. More recently, applications seeking information about the controversial ‘PM CARES fund’ were rejected, which was a form of financial aid collected from the citizens during the Covid 19 pandemic. Instead of helping transparency, the act has even proven to be lethal in some cases where from 2005 to 2020, at least 86 RTI applicants have been killed, 7 have committed suicide, over 170 people have been attacked and nearly 200 others have complained for harassment (Chhibber, 2020). This case study primarily explains the reluctance in a common Indian citizen when it comes to giving the government their hard earned money. In a country that’s reeking of corruption, lawlessness, favouritism and imbalance of power and accountability, the government would need to work harder to achieve public trust. On the other hand, the public need to be more educated and aware of their right to protest against injustice and demand accountability and most importantly, to not strengthen the corrupt machinery for their own petty needs. Ultimately, these

case studies show that trust building and taxation are two-way processes and involve both the government and the people to play their parts as and when needed.

4. Conclusion and recommendations

After having discussed taxation comprehensively; in its definitions, complexities and examples, it has been established that although there can be multiple factors affecting or leading to tax evasion, the unwillingness to pay taxes springs largely out of the government's incompetency. If the government wants people to pay their taxes dutifully, it should ensure that the money collected fills the infrastructural development of the country and not the pockets of its politicians. When the general middle class of the country struggles with basic amenities while the top rich enjoy themselves, it is not exactly unfair for them to try and save some money when they can.

Everyday, the newspapers across the country are loaded with headlines that outline the dilapidated condition of the middle and lower class; crime, infrastructural lapses, inflation and internal conflicts etc. The role of government in all of these areas seems either a formality or a half-hearted effort. For instance, less than 50 kms from the national capital, a disturbing case of sheer institutional failure appeared where a 27 year old young techie, who was a resource for his family and country and paid income taxes, drowned to his death in a ditch. His only fault was that he did not know about an underconstruction site which had dug a ditch and forgot to put a signboard there. Even though every possible authority including the police patrol team, the state and national disaster response forces and fire brigade reached the accident site, around 80 potential 'rescuers' acted like bystanders owing to 'protocols' and indecision and saw the victim succumb overnight (Dhaor, 2026). Around a month later in the national capital itself, another 25

year old fell to his doom in an uncovered pit dug by the Delhi *Jal* Board (water administration authority) and just 5 days later, a migrant labourer died in the same way. Although some of these cases attract suspensions and fines, by and large these issues are ignored until another mishap (NDTV news desk, 2026). These are just some random and recent examples from Delhi out of a plethora of incompetent actions by the state and central governments throughout the country.

Until the government focuses on gaining people's trust through legitimate welfare, providing job opportunities, health and transport infrastructure and crime control, it is rather foolish to expect people to do their duties as tax payers. Creating a structure which offers strict penalties but no genuine reason to pay taxes will only make the citizens come up with diverse and new ways to evade tax, a losing game for everyone involved.

It should be a shared responsibility of people and the government to raise awareness and disperse the rumours around taxation. Where on one hand, the government should introduce tax in schools, organize seminars in offices and promote a dialogue, the tax-payers should also put in effort to recognize their rights and duties, so as to effectively avoid penalties and imprisonment. While the authorities should devise a collaborative but not oppressive system for taxation, the people should also know the rules well. For instance, tax payers should take care of the minute details like regularly reviewing the Form 26AS and the Annual Information Statement (AIS) available on the income tax portal to verify that TDS/TCS details are correctly reflected and to ensure consistency in reported income (KotakLife, 2025) and the government should explain the necessity and concepts of tax to make sure it does not seem fearsome to people through education and awareness.

Tax laws should be simplified wherever possible so as to make it understandable to the general tax payer. At the same time, efforts should be directed at strengthening the enforcement

mechanisms and ensuring that defaulters are held accountable. If the process of taxation is built on fairness and equity, it leads to transparency between both the parties. People should be made to know their duties as well as rights. Taxation should be introduced in the schooling at early ages to de-complicate the mechanism for children and instill the values of charity and empathy in them. At a very fundamental level, the primary aim of the government should be to improve the everyday life of its citizens; areas that need reformation like education, transportation, crime and inflation etc. The onus of improper tax collections should be shared by people in government as well as tax payers and so, defaulters on other side should be brought to justice in the same fashion. Last but not the least, digital means and databases should be maintained effectively so as to monitor the process and stay at an arm's length from global co-operation too.

India's tax realm is undoubtedly one of the most complex in the world to sustain and monitor. This is because of its numerous rules, exemptions and other mechanisms that require knowledge which everyone does not possess. This gives way to certain professionals like chartered accountants, income tax consultants, GST consultants and advisors to read and understand the laws more than others and thereby, come up with loopholes that can successfully evade it. Taxation is certainly a very important tool to manage a country's growing demands for economic growth and development and so, it should be the job of the government to ensure that such a crucial system works well. This can be done by assuring the funds go to the right direction which aligns with the country's development and in their pursuit, not hurt the pockets of hardworking tax payers.

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